A Small Word Steals the Victory Speech

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Abdul El-Sayed has won a **Senate** seat in Michigan. He will be the first Muslim American U.S. senator. His parents came from Egypt.

At his victory party in Detroit on November 4, El-Sayed said a funny hello to Vice President JD Vance. He said, 'JD, habibi.' The word 'habibi' means 'my beloved' in Arabic. In everyday talk, it is more like 'buddy,' 'pal,' or 'bro.' Fans wore shirts that said 'Habibi for Abdul.'

During the race, Vance had warned that El-Sayed would lead **rioters** in burning down Detroit. El-Sayed joked that Vance must still swear him in as a senator in January. He also said his **campaign** turned 'inshallah,' or 'God willing,' into 'hamdulillah,' or 'thank God.'

People online shared music clips with the word 'habibi.' Egyptian **scholar** Khalil al-Anani called it the sweetest word and thanked El-Sayed for bringing joy to Egyptians.

El-Sayed had faced harsh words during the race. President Donald Trump called him a '**jihadist**,' brought up the September 11 attacks, and kept saying his name wrong. El-Sayed joked back that Trump can just call him 'senator.'

Word Treasure

Senate -- The Senate is a group of lawmakers who help make laws for the United States.

campaign -- A campaign is all the work a person does to try to win an election.

rioters -- Rioters are people in a crowd who act in a wild and violent way.

scholar -- A scholar is a person who has studied a subject for a long time and knows a lot about it.

jihadist -- It is a harsh word for a person who uses violence in the name of a strict form of Islam.

Background you need

A senator is one of the people voters choose to help make laws for the whole country in Washington, D.C.

When a candidate wins an election, they often give a victory speech to thank their supporters and share their hopes for the job ahead.

Habibi is a warm Arabic word that means my beloved, and friends often use it the way English speakers use buddy, pal, or bro.

Break it down

WHO: Abdul El-Sayed, who will be the first Muslim American U.S. senator, and Vice President JD Vance.

WHAT: El-Sayed won a Senate seat in Michigan and greeted Vance with 'JD, habibi' at his victory party.

WHERE: Detroit, Michigan, where El-Sayed held his victory party on November 4.

WHY: El-Sayed used humor and the Arabic word 'habibi' to answer the harsh warnings and name-calling he faced during the race.

Why it matters

It shows kids that words from their family's language can be shared with pride and bring joy to others.

Test what you remember

1. What did Abdul El-Sayed win?

- (A) A U.S. Senate seat in Michigan
- (B) A seat on the Detroit city council
- (C) The job of vice president
- (D) The job of governor of Michigan

2. What does the Arabic word "habibi" mean?

- (A) Thank God
- (B) My beloved
- (C) God willing
- (D) Good luck

3. Where was El-Sayed's victory party?

- (A) Washington, D.C.
- (B) New York City
- (C) Detroit
- (D) Cairo

4. Who did El-Sayed joke must still swear him in as a senator in January?

- (A) President Donald Trump
- (B) His parents
- (C) Vice President JD Vance
- (D) Khalil al-Anani

5. What did fans' shirts say at the victory party?

- (A) Thank God
- (B) Habibi for Abdul
- (C) Senator for Michigan
- (D) My Beloved Buddy

6. What did Egyptian scholar Khalil al-Anani say about the word "habibi"?

- (A) He said it was a rude word
- (B) He said it was hard to say
- (C) He said it meant 'goodbye'
- (D) He called it the sweetest word

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: B 3: C 4: C 5: B 6: D

Questions to think about

1. Vice President JD Vance: He warned during the race that El-Sayed would lead rioters in burning down Detroit.

2. President Donald Trump: He called El-Sayed a 'jihadist,' brought up the September 11 attacks, and kept saying his name wrong.

3. Egyptian scholar Khalil al-Anani: He called 'habibi' the sweetest word and thanked El-Sayed for bringing joy to Egyptians.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):